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Industry
Payments Pulse

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The Battle for Control Points

With this report, we launch Payments Pulse, our regular take on the developments shaping the payments landscape and their implications for our coverage. This week, Stripe expanded further into AI infrastructure and FX, while banks took another step toward interoperable tokenized deposits. The common thread is a widening battle for control of commerce and money movement. **For Adyen, the developments reinforce the strategic relevance of merchant ownership and a focused, integrated platform, although the near-term earnings implications are limited. For Wise, Stripe's expansion into FX introduces a more tangible competitive consideration, particularly within Wise Business.**

OpenRouter: Stripe Broadens, Adyen Stays Close to the Merchant

Stripe agreed this week to acquire OpenRouter, an AI model gateway that helps businesses route usage across more than 400 models from over 80 providers. The relationship itself is not new. OpenRouter was already using Stripe across payments, invoicing, tax, and fraud, but ownership would take Stripe materially further upstream into the infrastructure used by AI-native businesses.

The contrast with Adyen is becoming clearer. Stripe continues to widen its technology stack, while Adyen's recent expansion remains centered on merchant monetization and the customer relationship. Orb extends Adyen into billing, while Talon.One adds loyalty and promotions, but payments remain the connecting layer. We see merit in that focus. AI may increasingly influence discovery and customer acquisition, but merchants retain strong incentives to control pricing, identity, loyalty, and transaction economics. Adyen therefore does not need to follow Stripe into every layer of AI infrastructure to remain strategically important.

Our take: OpenRouter sharpens the strategic divergence. Stripe is broadening its infrastructure stack, while Adyen is deepening its position around the merchant. We see Adyen's focus as well placed, the merchant remains a key control point as AI reshapes commerce.

Stripe FX: A More Credible Competitor to Wise Business

Stripe also expanded its multi-currency capabilities this week, allowing businesses to manage FX directly within Stripe through broader multi-currency settlement and instant conversion. The clearest read-through is to Wise Business. A merchant already collecting internationally through Stripe can increasingly retain those funds, convert currencies, and pay out balances without moving money to another provider. That makes Stripe a more credible competitor across a part of the workflow currently served by Wise.

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Wise retains the stronger specialist infrastructure. Its network has been built over many years around local payment rails and cross-border money movement, with broader geographic and currency coverage. Stripe is not recreating that infrastructure. Its advantage is distribution and workflow ownership: the funds are already within the Stripe ecosystem. That lowers friction for the merchant and allows Stripe to bundle FX into an existing relationship rather than compete solely on the underlying cross-border product.

There is also some secondary overlap with Wise Platform, as Stripe can make FX capabilities available to platforms and their underlying merchants. However, Wise Platform remains the broader infrastructure proposition, embedding Wise's cross-border network into banks and other enterprises.

Our take: Stripe is becoming a more credible competitor where payments and FX converge within the same business workflow. Wise retains the stronger underlying cross-border proposition, but Stripe's ability to bundle FX around an existing merchant relationship creates another reason for customers to remain within its ecosystem. We see this as an incremental competitive consideration for Wise Business, rather than a direct challenge to Wise's network advantage today.

Tokenized Deposits: Banks Begin Improving the Rails

HSBC and Standard Chartered this week completed the first live cross-border tokenized deposit transaction using Swift's blockchain-based ledger, connecting tokenized deposits issued on two separate bank infrastructures. The significance lies less in the transaction itself than in the direction of travel. The debate around faster and programmable cross-border money has often focused on stablecoins, but banks are increasingly trying to deliver similar functionality through regulated commercial bank deposits.

For Wise, this remains a much longer-term consideration than Stripe FX. The transaction ultimately continued to rely on existing settlement infrastructure and is currently more relevant to institutional and corporate treasury flows than to Wise's core consumer and SME volumes. However, if tokenized deposits become interoperable across banks and jurisdictions, some of the friction supporting specialist cross-border propositions could gradually decline.

Our take: Tokenized deposits are not an immediate competitive threat to Wise, but they create another potential route through which incumbent banking infrastructure becomes faster, more programmable, and easier to use across borders. The longer-term cross-border debate is therefore broadening beyond stablecoins alone. See our stablecoin expert-call feedback [here](#).



Appendix 1

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Company	Ticker	Recent price	Disclosure
Adyen	ADYEN.AS	1,062.80 (EUR) 20 Aug 26	2, 14, 24
Wise PLC	WISEa.L	919.40 (GBX) 20 Aug 26	2, 14, 24

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Historical recommendations and target prices

Adyen (ADYEN.AS)



1.	9 Feb 24	Price target: 1,730.00 (EUR), close price 1,473.00 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Johannes Schaller
2.	23 Oct 24	Price target: 1,800.00 (EUR), close price 1,419.60 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
3.	6 Feb 25	Price target: 1,850.00 (EUR), close price 1,585.40 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
4.	14 Feb 25	Price target: 2,250.00 (EUR), close price 1,840.00 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
5.	17 Apr 25	Price target: 2,000.00 (EUR), close price 1,400.40 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
6.	15 Aug 25	Price target: 1,700.00 (EUR), close price 1,396.40 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
7.	30 Oct 25	Price target: 1,760.00 (EUR), close price 1,516.40 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
8.	4 Feb 26	Price target: 1,683.00 (EUR), close price 1,171.00 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
9.	13 Feb 26	Price target: 1,610.00 (EUR), close price 897.20 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
10.	27 Apr 26	Price target: 1,531.00 (EUR), close price 966.10 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
11.	23 Jul 26	Price target: 1,238.00 (EUR), close price 795.40 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
12.	14 Aug 26	Price target: 1,350.00 (EUR), close price 1,061.60 (EUR), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati



Wise PLC (WISEa.L)



1.	2 May 24	Price target: 950.00 (GBX), close price 787.50 (GBX), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: Kim Bergoe**
2.	14 Jun 24	Price target: 850.00 (GBX), close price 713.50 (GBX), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: Kim Bergoe**
3.	7 Nov 24	Price target: 810.00 (GBX), close price 820.00 (GBX), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
4.	17 Jan 25	Price target: 950.00 (GBX), close price 1,027.00 (GBX), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
5.	16 Apr 25	Price target: 990.00 (GBX), close price 968.00 (GBX), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati
6.	6 Nov 25	Price target: 940.00 (GBX), close price 910.00 (GBX), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: Nooshin Nejati

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Company rating dispersion and banking relationships

DBSI Companies under Coverage	Buy	Hold	Sell
Covered	57%	42%	0%
w/ Banking relationship	43%	35%	0%
w/ MiFID services	64%	51%	67%

Global Companies under Coverage	Buy	Hold	Sell
Covered	57%	40%	2%
w/ Banking relationship	46%	31%	26%
w/ MiFID services	75%	68%	89%

Company Rating and Dispersion Key

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